

A VIEW OF THE FUTURE
The rehabilitation project site in Elstone Estate, Kalpetta, Sept. 16

Takeaways

- **Centre refuses to declare Wayanad tragedy a 'national disaster', which would have entitled Kerala to more funds**
- **With polls due in 2026, the state has rushed work on a Rs 750 cr. 'Model Village' to rehouse survivors**

parties, with the Congress and Muslim League launching their own rehab projects, were not the only source of the surrounding din. Land acquisition posed hurdles, and both projects ended up in court. But 64.5 hectares at Elstone finally got legal clearance.

Wayanad district collector Meghashree D.R., a Karnataka native, bore witness to the crisis from day one: just 19 days into her posting when the landslides struck, she's been navigating the thicket of disputes and delays ever since. "On April 12, we got the government's word that the Supreme Court had cleared the way. We acquired the Elstone land the same day," she recalls.

The path to that point could vie to go into a textbook on cynicism. Sparking rage in most quarters in the state, the Centre refused to declare the tragedy a 'national disaster', which would have entitled Kerala to more funds. Then it made conditional whatever aid it was parting with as a 'capital expenditure loan'—the Rs 529.5 crore released in February this year came with a caveat that the sum be used by March 31 or it would attract penalties.

Then, it was after 14 months of repeated requests from the state's political class as well as Kerala High Court directives that a committee chaired by Union home minister Amit Shah approved Rs 260.56 crore from the National Disaster Response Fund. The demand, based on Post-Disaster Needs Assessment, was for Rs 2,221 crore. BJP-ruled Assam and Uttarakhand, meanwhile, received Rs 1,270 crore and Rs 1,658 crore, respectively. Perhaps there's no grace in competitive victimhood, but Kerala clearly felt orphaned.

LIVE TO TELL THE TALE

Persistent rains are not the only obstacle at Elstone, there's also a parallel disruption in the face of a vigilance probe on charges that the beneficiaries' list has been tampered with. But work is proceeding apace across the project's five zones. Nearing October, there were some 500 workers on site. Plans include a soccer ground, market and open-air theatre. J.S. Arun, the project's chief operating officer, is confident of being able to "avoid further delays". Among the survivors, 104 families have opted out of the project, choosing to go for a Rs 15 lakh compensation.

Most survivors are still picking up the thread of their lives. Basheer, 60, ran a bustling tea shop at Chooralmala for 30 years, but is now a waiter. It's a whole universe he has lost. "I miss my daily customers and friends," he says, preparing one of his famous 'meter teas'. "They are all dead." Mundakkai, too, stands deserted by everyone except ghosts and police pickets—even the Punnapuzha river has changed course.

M.T. Aneesh, 37, has managed to rebuild his life, working as a jeep driver/ guide at 900 Kandi, an ecotourism spot. But a quiet ritual pulls him and his wife Sayana to a different site that now houses three of their kids—the youngest a baby—as well as Aneesh's mother. A mass graveyard in Puthumala. "Sometimes, we bring chocolates and toys, and we can almost hear them cheering... they always wanted chocolates when I got back from work." ■